

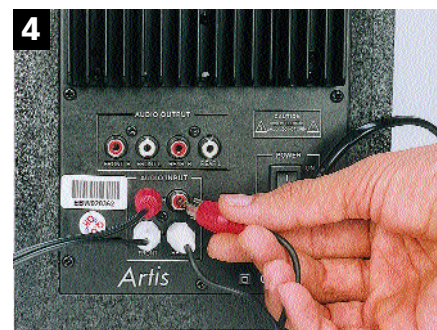
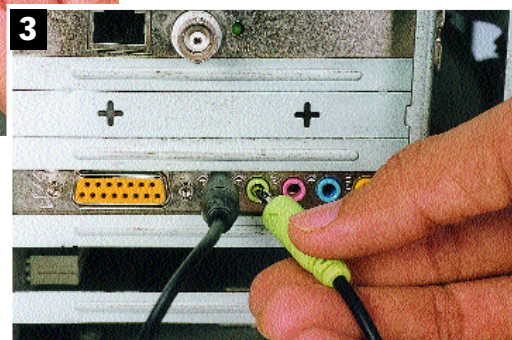
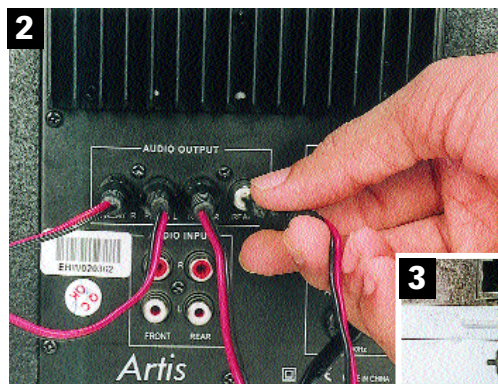
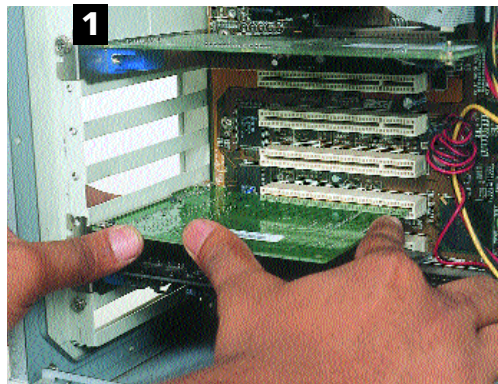
Say Goodbye to Stereo

Until not too long ago, surround sound on your computer meant four-point surround. Soundcards that offered two front and two rear stereo outputs were the *de facto* standard for budget home theater computer systems as they were cheap and adequately placed audio around the listener.

Today, thanks to standards such as Dolby Digital and DTS (Digital Theatre System), you have fully compliant six-channel sound-

cards that can decode Dolby Digital audio streams. The best part is that these cards are now available for outrageously low prices, bringing home theatre to your PC. This includes cards like Creative's SoundBlaster Live! 5.1 DE, which is available for just a couple of hundred rupees more than its four-channel counterpart. This new breed of cards features six discrete channels of sound output and the job of decoding the Dolby

Digital audio stream is done onboard instead of by the system's processor. They also feature pass-through functionality where the Dolby Digital audio signal can be passed onto an external decoder as well, if necessary. What's more, sound subsystems on motherboards such as those based on the nForce chipset already exhibit full Dolby Digital compliance. This has effectively raised the bar on the audio subsystems on PCs.



The INVAR coating ensures that you do not get eyestrain while sitting through even three-hour DVDs. And the good news is that it is one of the lower priced monitors in its size category.

Price: Rs 21,000

Getting it all together

Once you have the tools for enabling surround sound on your PC, the next thing is to grab a screwdriver—we need to get under the hood of your computer!

Install and configure the soundcard: Find a vacant PCI slot on your motherboard and insert the soundcard, taking care to exert even pressure along the entire soundcard. Now start up your computer; Windows will find the new soundcard as it loads up. Keep the soundcard's driver CD handy and insert it into the DVD drive (or CD-ROM drive) when prompted. Your soundcard will get detected and the drivers will be installed by the system.



Tweak to Perfection

Every multi-channel soundcard bundles its own dedicated application that lets you test the various channels and configure it for optimum surround sound playback. Creative soundcards have an application through which you can verify if all your channels are properly functioning. Through this application, you can also set the levels of these channels so that you have balanced audio from each of the speakers in your surround sound system.

To enable true four-channel sound in your system, you will need to set your soundcard's configuration to recognise four channels instead of the default two channels. Right-click on the speaker icon in the system tray and select *Adjust Audio Properties > Advanced Properties for Playback*. From the Speaker Setup drop-down list, select *Quadro-Phonic Speakers*.

Connect and place the speakers: A four-point surround speaker set will have four satellite speakers and one subwoofer. Therefore, these speakers will have four inputs—two for the front speakers (left and right) and two for the rear (left and right) that will have to be connected to your soundcard. The satellites will be connected to the subwoofer itself. First place the front speakers on either side of your monitor. Then, place the rear speakers behind you.

Connect the 3.5 mm stereo jack from the Front Out of your sound-

1. Insert the soundcard into a vacant PCI slot
2. Connect the satellite speakers to the subwoofer
3. Connect the speakers to your soundcard's front and rear outputs
4. Finally, connect the soundcard to the subwoofer

card to the Front In on the subwoofer, and the Rear Out from your soundcard to the Rear In on the subwoofer. Finally, connect the front speakers to the Front channel output on the subwoofer and the rear speakers to the Rear channel output. The front/back, left/right channels would be clearly indicated on the subwoofer.

Calibrate the speakers: If your speakers are not running at the optimum signal levels, you will either hear distortion due to a high signal level or the volume would be too low with some channels during playback.